



SIPA JAS

RUSSIAN CHILL

GAP WIDENS: Putin with Singh

as to remain in power and overcome the constitutional hurdle that does not allow a third consecutive term to a President. This may be a way of preparing for the emerging power structure.

Not surprisingly, there is concern in the South Block as this is not an isolated incident. Last month too, India had got a taste of Russia's diplomatic snub when External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee had visited Moscow for the joint commis-

As India cosies up to the US, its distance with all-weather friend Russia gets wider. Will Manmohan be able to bridge it?

As Prime Minister Manmohan Singh heads to Moscow on November 11 for his eighth summit meeting with Russian President Vladimir Putin to take the strategic ties forward, turbulence seems to have hit the Indo-Russian relations. This is in sharp contrast to the warmth India once shared with its all-weather friend. While at the centre of the controversy is what seems like a protocol hurdle, sources say the Russians are believed to be upset at India's growing strategic alignment with the US, considering that the US-Russia relations are at an all-time low, and Putin is at loggerheads with the Bush Administration.

The Indian advance security liaison team, which was in Moscow last month to prepare for Singh's visit, was told by the Russian protocol officials that the Indian prime minister's visit would be treated as a working one, not an official one unless he met their prime minister. They added that according to protocol his counterpart was the Russian prime minister, knowing well that in India the prime minister is the head of the government and the usual protocol is that Putin is his counterpart. The Indian officials were taken aback by the Russian rebuff since there was no separate meeting held with the Russian prime minister

in December 2005, when Singh was on a bilateral visit to Moscow. Besides, the Russians used to go out of the way to welcome Indian prime ministers. When Atal Bihari Vajpayee visited Moscow in 2003, Putin had arranged a separate dinner for him in his Dacha.

Now the prime minister will meet his new Russian counterpart, Viktor Zubkov, on November 12 although it is yet to be decided who will call on whom or if they will meet at a third place. That all was not well was evident as the Ministry of External Affairs issued a bland statement without giving any details of the visit which was unusual.

The Russians, however, maintain that all is well. "We have a good bilateral relationship and your biggest overseas project Sakhalin-1 is in Russia. We had scheduling problems earlier with the visit of Pranab Mukherjee and we just want your prime minister to get to know our new prime minister," remarked a senior diplomat. Also, there are rumours that Putin may opt to be prime minister after his second term of presidency ends in March 2008 so

sion meeting. The agenda was to prepare ground for the summit between the heads of the two governments, but a meeting with both Putin and his foreign minister Sergei Lavrov was denied to Mukherjee. Then to add injury to the insult, Mukherjee was frisked at the Moscow airport, while New Delhi made a formal demarche to Moscow on the issue. Officials in the Indian Mission in Moscow were pulled up, but the Russians were unapologetic.

Russia gains little by jeopardising its ties when defence contracts worth \$14.2 billion (Rs 55,825 crore) are underway with India. Besides, if the Indo-US nuclear deal had passed through, it would have been able to resume nuclear trade with India.

But India has reason to be upset because some defence projects with Russian collaboration are running behind schedule and their after sales

service is also poor. Sources say instructions have been issued to cut the access of the Russian envoy in New Delhi if Moscow does not mend fences. The patch-up though is expected during Singh's visit as both countries are aware of the long-term interests at stake.

by Saurabh Shukla

According to a new protocol diktat, Manmohan will have to meet the Russian prime minister to make his visit official.